RAJASTHAN

WALKING A TIGHTROPE

By Rohit Parihar



ANI

Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot is in anything but a happy place. With assembly election due in December next year, his MLAs are under pressure to take up issues and deliver results, but their efforts to do so are often ending up in run-ins with officials. Worse, the kin of some of the legislators have been accused of committing serious crimes. Gehlot's predicament is that he has to defend his men even while making it appear that the law would prevail. He doesn't have much space for manoeuvre given the slim majority his party has in the assembly. With 102 seats in the 200-member assembly, the Congress is heavily reliant on the six BSP MLAs who joined it in 2019—a merger that is under judicial scrutiny—and the Independents. The turncoat MLAs have been disgruntled for being denied ministerial berths due to resistance from Sachin Pilot, whose rebellion in 2020 failed to topple the government but has kept it on tenterhooks.

Gehlot's statement to the media on May 19 gives an indication of the razor's edge he is walking on. "It's right to lodge FIRs against MLAs when something unwarranted happens at their meetings, but it's not right for the media or others to nail leaders for wrongs done by their kin, as that amounts to influencing investigations," he said. In the backdrop is a series of incidents involving party leaders or their kin that have cast a shadow over the CM's image. According to an AICC official, these "incidents are a fallout of Gehlot's strategy of giving his ministers and MLAs a long rope to keep them in good humour".

Take the Congress deputy chief whip Mahendra Singh Chaudhary, for example. On May 17, the Rajasthan police arrested his brother Moti Singh along with four others after Rashtriya Loktantrik Party MP Hanuman Beniwal threatened to lead a march to Jaipur demanding their arrests and a CBI probe. Moti Singh has been accused of hiring a sharpshooter to kill Jaipal Poonia, a rival in the salt trade. Poonia was murdered on May 14 in Nagaur district.

Cabinet minister and chief whip Mahesh Joshi, too, is facing a serious allegation. In an FIR lodged with the Delhi Police, a young news anchor from the minority community has accused his son Rohit of raping her. She has also accused the chief whip of influencing the Jaipur police, who allegedly brought her from Delhi to Jaipur in February in order to force her to sign some papers. Rohit, who is married and has a son, is yet to turn up before the Delhi Police, which came looking for him at his father's official residence. Instead, Rohit has moved the Delhi High Court seeking the quashing of the FIR. In his petition, he alleged that he was "honey-trapped" after the complainant sent him a friend request on Facebook. The plea is listed for hearing on July 26.

CM ASHOK GEHLOT HAS TO DEFEND HIS LOYALISTS, BUT CAN'T BE SEEN TO BE STANDING IN LAW'S WAY

While Gehlot seemed to be defending both his chief whip and deputy chief whip, arguing there is no evidence that they were influencing the investigations, he had to justify the FIR against Rajasthan Youth Congress chief Ganesh Ghogra. Ghogra resigned as MLA on May 18, a day after he had a stand-off with the Dungarpur district administration over distribution of land deeds. A case was registered against Ghogra and others for